

Introducing Imam ‘Alī and his Spiritual Ethos

I am the city of knowledge and ‘Alī is its gate;
so whoever desires knowledge, let him enter the gate.
(*Anā madīnātu’l- ilm wa ‘Alī bābuḥāḡ*;
Fa-man arāda’l- ilm fal-ya ti’t-bāb).¹

To speak of ‘Alī b. Abī Ṭalīb—cousin and son-in-law of the Prophet Muḥammad, fourth caliph of Islam and first in the line of Shi‘i Imams—is to speak of the quintessential spirituality of the Islamic tradition. For in this seminal figure of nascent Islam, one finds an integral expression of the two fundamental sources of Islamic spirituality, the Qur’ānic revelation and the inspired *Sunna* of the Prophet.² By his *Sunna* we do not mean simply the outward imitation of the Prophet’s actions—a reductionism all too prevalent in our times—rather, we mean the spiritual substance of the prophetic perfection to which the Qur’ān itself refers: ‘Verily, thou art of a tremendous nature’ (68: 4).³ The Prophet’s words and deeds express but do not exhaust this spiritual substance. The inner assimilation of this substance, rather than the merely formal imitation of the words and deeds, is the goal of every spiritually inclined Muslim. There is a profound affinity between the believer’s soul and the prophetic nature, a mysterious proximity that goes beyond time and space, as expressed in the verse: ‘The Prophet is closer to the believers than they are to themselves’ (33: 6). The Prophet, thus, outwardly manifests the perfection which the spiritually sensitive believer intuits, to some degree or another, as determining the very essence of his or her own soul.⁴

It is not surprising, therefore, to find the Prophet saying that ‘Alī ‘is as my own soul (*ka-nafsi*)’,⁵ affirming thereby not only the extraordinarily close relationship between ‘Alī and himself, but also the affinity—and ultimately, identity—between every sanctified soul and the prophetic nature. More mysteriously, he said to ‘Alī, ‘You are from me, and I am from you (*anta minnī wa anā minka*).’⁶ Likewise, as regards ‘Alī’s assimilation of the substance of the Qur’ān, we have this prophetic saying: ‘Alī is with the Qur’ān and the Qur’ān is with ‘Alī. They will not separate from each other until they return to me at the [paradisa] pool (*al-ḥawḡ*).’⁷ The spirit of the Qur’ān and the soul of the Prophet were thus fully interiorized by ‘Alī, and it is this interiorization of the twin sources of the Islamic revelation which constitutes the spiritual path of Islam.

Our principal way of investigating and meditating upon the spirituality of Imam ‘Alī is to consider the corpus of teachings attributed to him. Even if not all of the thousands of sayings attributed to him can be confidently ascribed to him, the very magnitude of the corpus testifies to the fact that he must indeed have articulated a very large number of profound teachings. No other companion of the Prophet has anything approaching the corpus attributed to ‘Alī. Similarly, even if his foundational role in the development of a whole range of sciences be debatable—sciences such as jurisprudence (*fiqh*), theology (*kalām*), Qur’ānic exegesis (*tafsīr*), rhetoric (*balāgha*), grammar (*naḥw*) and calligraphy (*khaṡṡ*), the mystical knowledge associated with Sufism, as well as such arcane sciences as numerology (*jaḡr*) and alchemy (*al-kīmiyā*)⁸—the fact that he is considered by later authorities in these fields as having provided the initial impetus for their sciences bespeaks the far-reaching and penetrating influence of both his formal teachings and personal radiance.

Given that the Islamic intellectual sciences as a whole are so closely identified with ‘Alī, the Prophet’s definition of ‘Alī as the ‘gate’ to prophetic wisdom, cited as our epigraph, takes on the appearance of both a description of what ‘Alī was in relation to the Prophet in their own age, and also a prophecy of the role ‘Alī would play in relation to the subsequent unfolding of the sciences of the tradition—all such sciences being understood as so many formal, outward manifestations of the essential, inward spirit of the Islamic revelation, that spirit which was synthetically assimilated and faithfully transmitted by Imam ‘Alī. But before proceeding any further, the main historical outlines of his life should be sketched out.

BIOGRAPHICAL SKETCH

‘Alī was a ‘follower’ of the Prophet in the deepest sense of the term. He lived physically in the shadow of the Prophet and absorbed spiritually all that radiated from him. The intimacy of the relationship between them is summed up in the words of one of the Imam’s sermons:

When I was but a child he took me under his wing ... I would follow him [the Prophet] as a baby camel follows the footsteps of its mother. Every day he would raise up for me a sign of his noble character, commanding me to follow it. He would go each year into seclusion at [the mountain of] Ḥira’. I saw him and nobody else saw him. At that time no household was brought together for the religion of Islam, except [that comprising] the Messenger of God, Khadija and myself as the third. I saw the light of the revelation and the message, and I smelt the fragrance of prophecy ...⁹

It is ‘Alī as the faithful follower and transmitter of the prophetic norm that we wish to address in this biographical sketch. Thus, we shall take a glance at the early period of his life, from his birth (c. 599 ce) to the death of the Prophet (11/632). Neither the second period of his life, from the death of the Prophet to his own assumption of the caliphate (35/656), nor the third period, consisting of his brief caliphate, dominated by tragic civil wars and culminating with his assassination in 40/661, will be dealt with here, as the issues raised in this part of his biography are fraught with historical and historiographical complexities.¹⁰ Such controversies will deflect us from the primary aim of this book, which is to introduce the spiritual ethos of this extraordinary figure in such a way as to demonstrate its universal relevance, both within Islam itself and also beyond the Islamic tradition. For this ethos transcends formal religious boundaries, just as it rises above the political issues upon which the outward aspect of the Shi‘i-Sunni divergence is based—such issues serving only to distract attention from the essential spiritual message of ‘Alī.

What we wish to draw attention to here, on the contrary, is the unifying force of his spiritual teachings, upon the immense importance and profundity of which all Muslims, whatever their school of thought, are in agreement. In what follows, then, we shall briefly survey the earlier period of 'Alī's life, that spent with the Prophet, together with the way in which the Prophet described 'Alī in well-attested sayings, as this constitutes the indispensable background against which his role as gate to prophetic wisdom should be viewed. The second part of this introductory chapter will then address some key principles of his spiritual ethos, with a particular stress on the role of the intellect in that ethos.

According to all Shi'i authorities and several Sunni sources, 'Alī had the unique distinction of being born in the Ka'ba in Mecca.¹¹ His mother was Fāṭima bt. Asad, and his father, Abū Ṭalīb, son of 'Abd al-Muṭṭalib, was a leading member of the clan of the Hashimites. Abū Ṭalīb had taken care of the young orphan, Muḥammad, son of his brother 'Abd Allāh, and was later to be his chief protector when the message of Islam was openly being preached in Mecca. Several years before his mission began, at a time of drought, Muḥammad relieved the pressure on Abū Ṭalīb and took his young son 'Alī, then about five years old, into his own household. From this time on 'Alī was like a son to him, rarely being separated from him.

'Alī is regarded as the first male to enter the religion of Islam, though he was but a youth of nine or ten years old. Abū Bakr was the first adult male to enter the new religion, and Khadija, the Prophet's wife, was the first woman. The immediacy of the young boy's response to the prophetic message and his unflinching loyalty to the Prophet thereafter is of great significance. When, about three years later, the Prophet was instructed by the revelation to 'warn thy nearest kin' (26: 214), he invited the leading members of his clan to a feast, after which he addressed them thus: 'O sons of 'Abd al-Muṭṭalib, I know of no Arab who hath come to his people with a nobler message than mine. I bring you the best of this world and the next. God hath commanded me to call you unto Him. Which of you, then, will help me in this, and be my brother, mine executor and my successor amongst you?' All remained silent, except for the youthful 'Alī who spoke up: 'O Prophet of God, I will be thy helper in this.' The Prophet then placed his hand on 'Alī's neck and said, 'This is my brother, mine executor and my successor amongst you. Harken unto him and obey him.'¹² Although at the time this was greeted with mockery by the leaders of the clan, it was taken much more seriously as time went on, and the extraordinary character, nobility and intelligence of the Prophet's young cousin became ever more dazzlingly evident.

Also of importance in this early period is the role played by 'Alī in the migration (*hijra*) from Mecca to Medina (622 CE), the event which marks the beginning of the Muslim calendar. The enemies of the Prophet had planned to assassinate him, and knowing this, 'Alī risked his own life by pretending to be the Prophet, sleeping in the latter's bed on the night he departed.¹³ In Medina, the Prophet adopted 'Alī as his 'brother' in the pact of brotherhood he established between the 'emigrants' (*al-muhājirīn*), that is, the Muslims who accompanied the Prophet on the *hijra* from Mecca, and the 'helpers' (*al-anṣār*), the tribes of Medina who had embraced the new faith.¹⁴

In the Medinan period, 'Alī distinguished himself on the field of battle, as a scribe of the unfolding revelation of the Qur'ān, and as a leading companion of the Prophet. His courage and heroism in the battles fought against the overwhelmingly superior forces of the Meccan Quraysh and their allies was second to none. 'Alī was at the forefront of nearly all the major battles fought under the Prophet's banner, frequently being appointed as standard-bearer. He was undefeated in all the single-combat duels with which the battles normally began—indeed, he was never defeated in any battle in which he fought. Both his indomitable courage and incomparable skill as a warrior became legendary. It is said that during the battle of Uhud, a heavenly voice was heard proclaiming, 'There is no chivalric knight but 'Alī, no sword but *dhu'l-faḡār* (*lā fatā illā 'Alī, lā sayf illā dhu'l-faḡār*)', the latter being the name of 'Alī's sword given to him by the Prophet. But the most famous of all battles in establishing 'Alī's reputation as the pre-eminent—indeed invincible—warrior of Islam was that of Khaybar in 7/629. The Muslims were unable to make any headway against the heavily fortified, apparently impregnable, defences of their opponents. The Prophet then declared that he would give the banner of his army to one who 'loves God and His Messenger and is loved by God and His Messenger', through whom victory would be granted. He sent for 'Alī, who was absent because of an affliction of the eyes. The Prophet cured him of this ailment by placing some saliva upon his eyes, and 'Alī proceeded to lead the Muslims to victory. In the thick of battle, having lost his own shield, he is said to have picked up a gate and used it as a shield—a gate which, after the battle, could only be lifted by eight men.¹⁵

'Alī's role as a warrior is but one of many factors making for his unique place in the Islamic tradition. Of much greater significance is his proximity, in all respects, to the Prophet, and the wisdom and sanctity flowing from this proximity. 'Alī was given the immense honour of marrying the Prophet's daughter, Fāṭima, considered to be the most saintly woman in Islam, along with her mother, the Prophet's first wife, Khadija. One of the epithets bestowed on Fāṭima in the tradition is *Majma' al-Nūrāyn*, 'Confluence of the Two Lights'—the two lights of *nubāwwa* (prophecy) and of *walāya* (sanctity). 'Alī was thus, after the Prophet, the leader of what was known as the *Ahl al-Bayt*, 'the People of the House', that is, the family of the Prophet.¹⁶

The Ahl al-Bayt are referred to in an important Qur'ānic verse as being purified of all defilement: 'God only wisheth to remove from you all impurity, O People of the House, and to purify you with a complete purification' (33: 33). According to several of the most important early sources, the Prophet called for Fāṭima, 'Alī and their two sons, Ḥasan and Ḥusayn, and said, 'This is my Ahl al-Bayt'.¹⁷ On one occasion, according to most sources, the Prophet took these members of his family under his cloak and recited the words of this verse. This event took place when a Christian delegation from Najrān was engaging in religious debate with the Prophet, and a verse was revealed indicating that a challenge of mutual imprecation (*mubāhila*) be made to the Christians. The Prophet brought the four persons mentioned above for this *mubāhila*, but the Christians declined the challenge.¹⁸

The importance of the Ahl al-Bayt is expressed in another verse in which the Prophet is instructed, 'Say: I ask you for no reward, save love of the near of kin' (42: 23). According to several of the most important commentators of the Qur'ān, the referent of 'near of kin' in this verse is the Prophet's Ahl al-Bayt.¹⁹ Love of the Prophet's family is thus explicitly called for by the revelation, without this excluding the more general import of the verse, love of all those with whom one shares close kinship ties. The extent to which the Prophet's family are to be revered by all Muslims is also indicated in the fact that blessings are to be invoked upon his *āl*, or progeny, as part of the blessings to be invoked upon him. The Qur'ān instructs the believers: 'Truly, God and His angels bless the Prophet. O ye who believe, bless him and greet him with peace' (33: 56). Upon the revelation of this verse, the Prophet was asked how one was to perform this blessing, and he replied that the blessings were to be invoked upon him and his *āl* as follows: 'O God, bless Muḥammad and the progeny of Muḥammad, as Thou hast blessed Abraham and the progeny of Abraham. Truly, Thou art the Praised, the Glorious ...'²⁰ The importance of this blessing, to be recited during the canonical prayer, together with the necessity of loving the Prophet's family, is well brought out in the following lines of a poem by Imām al-Shāfi'i, founder of one of the four schools of Sunni jurisprudence:

Loving you, O family of the household of the Prophet of God, is an obligation (*farāḍ*) from God in the Qur'an which He revealed; Sufficient to show the grandeur of your dignity is that one who blesses you not—no prayer has he.²¹

It is also important to take note of the following Prophetic saying indicating the spiritual importance of the Ahl al-Bayt:

Truly, I am leaving behind amongst you the two weighty things (*al-thaqalayn*): the Book of God and my Ahl al-Bayt, they will not be parted from each other until they return to me at the [paradisa]l pool] *al-ḥawḍ*.²²

In addition to these sayings concerning 'Alī as the most important member of the Prophet's Ahl al-Bayt, there are sayings of the Prophet concerning 'Alī specifically, which deserve to be cited in detail, as it is only the basis of these sayings that one can begin to appreciate the immensely important role of 'Alī in the spiritual dimension of the Islamic faith. These sayings or traditions (*ahādīth*, sing. *ḥadīth*) will be presented in the form of a list, with minimal comment, this being the way in which they are presented in most standard collections of *ahādīth*. If one takes prophetic guidance seriously, one cannot but take 'Alī seriously, and it is largely for this reason that countless Muslims through the centuries have meditated upon these sayings, drawing from them diverse interpretations as well as incalculable inspiration. In a certain sense, these sayings are like the prism through which 'Alī is viewed by the tradition, and they serve to enhance one's spiritual receptivity to his teachings. The crucial importance of 'Alī in the spiritual firmament of